



Choosing Your First NaNDA Dataset

Breakout handout, beginner track. GSA 2026 Virtual Workshop, October 7, 2026.

Everything you need for this breakout is on this page. Keep it open next to Zoom.

Want to type your answers? Make your own copy: File, then Make a copy. If you'd rather not, the Zoom chat works just as well.

Links you'll use

- [Browse NaNDA datasets by topic on the NaNDA website](#) (the easiest place to see what exists; each dataset links to its ICPSR page)
- [Search NaNDA datasets on ICPSR](#) (where the files, codebooks, and citations live)
- [Book a NaNDA Office Hours appointment](#)
- [Read NaNDA's guide to geographies \(tracts, ZCTAs, and 2010 vs. 2020 boundaries\)](#)
- [Questions after today? Email \[nanda-admin@umich.edu\]\(mailto:nanda-admin@umich.edu\)](#)

Three questions for choosing a dataset

Question	What you're asking
Where?	What location information does my data have, and which census boundaries (2010 or 2020) is it based on?
When?	What years were my data collected, and which NaNDA years match them?
What?	Which neighborhood feature do I want to measure, and which variable captures it?



Words to know

- **Census tract:** a small area defined by the Census Bureau, usually home to 1,200 to 8,000 people. Every tract sits inside exactly one county, so tract-level measures can be added up to the county level. Most NaNDA measures are available for tracts.
- **ZCTA (ZIP Code Tabulation Area):** the Census Bureau's area-based version of a ZIP code, built from census blocks. ZCTAs cut across tract and county lines, so they don't add up to anything.
- **ZIP code:** a U.S. Postal Service mail delivery route, not an area. A ZIP code and its ZCTA don't always match, so ZIP codes need a crosswalk (a lookup table) before you can link them to NaNDA.
- **FIPS code (also called a GEOID):** a number that identifies a place. It grows as the place gets smaller: 2 digits for the state (26 is Michigan), 3 more for the county (26161 is Washtenaw County), 6 more for the tract (26161400100 is tract 4001.00). Keep it stored as text so leading zeros survive; Alabama is state 01.
- **Geographic boundaries:** which census the boundaries come from. Tracts and ZCTAs were redrawn for 2020, so 2010 codes and 2020 codes don't line up. The boundaries follow the date your data were geocoded, not the year of your survey.
- **Geocoding:** turning an address into a location code, such as a census tract.
- **Codebook (or data dictionary):** the document that lists every variable in a dataset and what it means.

Follow along: Jordan's study

Dr. Jordan Ellis (they/them) studies loneliness among adults 65 and older. Their study followed the same participants from 2016 to 2019, interviewing them every year. Home addresses were collected at enrollment in 2016 and geocoded to census tracts. Jordan isn't sure which tract boundaries those codes use. Jordan's question: do older adults who live near more places to gather (clubs, community groups, places of worship) report less loneliness?

The table below is also your worksheet. Jordan's answers are filled in. Use the last column for your own project.

Question	Jordan's answer	Your answer
Where?	Census tract codes, geocoded in 2016. The 2020 boundaries didn't exist yet, so these are 2010 boundaries. Use NaNDA's Census Tract 2010 file and link on the variable tract_fips10.	
When?	Interviews in 2016, 2017, 2018 and 2019. The civic organizations data has a value for every year from 1990 to 2022, so each interview year has a match. Neighborhood poverty comes from a period dataset with one value per 5-year window. Only 2008 to 2012 and 2013 to 2017 use 2010 boundaries, so use 2013 to 2017. Note the gap for 2018 and 2019 in your methods.	
What?	Civic and social organizations per 1,000 people (den_civsoc) and religious organizations per 1,000 people (den_religiousorgs). Neighborhood poverty: proportion of people below the poverty line, from the Socioeconomic Status dataset.	
Dataset	Civic, Social, and Religious Organizations by Census Tract and	

Question	Jordan's answer	Your answer
	ZCTA, United States, 1990-2022. National Neighborhood Data Archive (NaNDA): Socioeconomic Status and Demographic Characteristics of Census Tracts and ZIP Code Tabulation Areas, United States, 1990-2022 (Tract10 2013-2017 file) Save the citation and DOI to your reference manager as soon as you find it.	

Two kinds of timing

- **Yearly datasets** give one value per place per year. Match the year your data were collected. Example: Civic, Social, and Religious Organizations, 1990 to 2022.
- **Period datasets** give one estimate that covers several years, often from the Census Bureau's American Community Survey. Pick the period that overlaps your data collection the most. Example: [Socioeconomic Status and Demographic Characteristics of Census Tracts and ZIP Code Tabulation Areas, United States, 1990-2022](#), where each file covers a range of years.

Boundaries come first. A file with the right years but the wrong boundaries (for example, 2020 tracts when your data uses 2010 tracts) won't link cleanly.

Close is usually fine. Neighborhoods change slowly, so a gap of a year or two between your data and NaNDA's is common. Just note it in your methods.

Where to look on a dataset's ICPSR page

- **The title** usually tells you the topic, the geography, and the years.
- **Data and documentation** lists each file, with its boundaries and years.



- **Notes** often include a "Choosing a Dataset" section that explains which file to use.
- **Variables** (or the codebook) shows the location variable and every measure.
- **Cite data** gives you the citation and DOI. Add it to Zotero or your reference manager right away.

Location variables in recent NaNDA datasets. Older datasets may use different names, so check the codebook.

Variable	What it is
tract_fips10	Census tract, 2010 boundaries (11 digits)
tract_fips20	Census tract, 2020 boundaries (11 digits)
tract_fips22	Census tract for Connecticut after its 2022 county change (found in 2020 tract files)
zcta10	ZCTA, 2010 boundaries (5 digits)
zcta20	ZCTA, 2020 boundaries (5 digits)

Scavenger hunt

Pick one prompt. [Search NaNDA datasets on ICPSR](#), find a dataset that fits, and post its name in the chat. Tip: search a single plain word, like grocery, transit, or internet.

Prompt	Topic	Years	Geography
1	Food access: grocery stores	2016	Census tract, 2010 boundaries



Prompt	Topic	Years	Geography
2	Getting around: public transit stops	2016 to 2018	ZCTA
3	Staying connected: internet access at home	2015 to 2019	Census tract

Your turn

Fill in the "Your answer" column in Jordan's table, then find one dataset you would actually consider using. [Browse by topic on the NaNDA website](#), then open the dataset's ICPSR page for its files and variables.

- **Not sure which boundaries your data use?** Ask when the addresses were geocoded. Before 2020 almost always means 2010 boundaries. If you don't know, ask whoever geocoded the data, or check the codebook.
- **Not sure what location information you have at all?** Check your study's codebook or data use agreement. Many aging studies, such as HRS and NHATS, release geography only through restricted data agreements. It's fine to plan around what the restricted file offers.
- **Have county-level data?** Any tract-level NaNDA dataset can be added up to counties, so the whole tract catalog is open to you.
- **Have ZIP codes?** You'll need a crosswalk to ZCTAs first. NaNDA shares [code for merging NaNDA ZCTA datasets with a ZIP code to ZCTA crosswalk](#), and the intermediate track covers this step.
- **Can't find your topic?** Book Office Hours or email nanda-admin@umich.edu and tell us what you're looking for. User requests shape what NaNDA builds next.

After today

- [Book a NaNDA Office Hours appointment](#) for help choosing or linking a dataset.



- Cite the dataset you use. The "Cite data" or "Cite this study" button on its ICPSR page gives you the citation and DOI.

Scavenger hunt answers

1. [Grocery and Food Stores by Census Tract and ZCTA, United States, 1990-2022](#). Use the Census Tract 2010 file.
2. [Public Transit Stops by Census Tract and ZIP Code Tabulation Area, United States, 2016-2018 and 2024](#). Use the ZCTA 2016-2018 file.
3. [Internet Access by Census Tract and ZIP Code Tabulation Area, United States, 2015-2019](#). Use the census tract file. Also a good answer: [Broadband Internet Availability, Speed, and Adoption by Census Tract and ZIP Code Tabulation Area, United States, 2014-2020](#).